consciousness went hand in hand with the expansion of its presence, and is reflected in the accommodation of a larger geography over time in the hymns of the Vedas. As opposed to being the subject of conquest and dominion, Bharat is treated as an object of worship, with respect for its geographical attributes being richly reflected in the hymns. This brings out the fundamental divergence between the attitudes of Middle Eastern and European colonialities to Bharat and nature on the one hand, and the attitude of the indigenous Indic consciousness towards its sacred geography on the other. On this, Mookerji has the following to say[15]:

> The perennial beauty of the Himalayas has captivated the national imagination and has made them the refuge of holy men, drawing unending streams of pilgrims. Indeed, the Hindu's pilgrimages are always to the glacier-clad mountain, the palm-clad sea-shore or ocean-isle, or the almost impenetrable depths of hill and jungle, where the tread of the generations of Man has scarcely been heard, and Nature left free to exercise her healing and healthful influence. Thus, the Indian treats the beauty of place in a peculiar way, foreign to the West: his method of appreciating and celebrating it is quite different. A spot of beauty is no place for social enjoyment or self-indulgence; it is the place for self-restraint, for solitary meditation which leads the mind from nature up to Nature's God.
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> Had Niagara been situated on the Ganges, how different would have been its valuation by humanity. Instead of occasional picnics and railway pleasure-trips, the perennial pilgrimage of worshipping crowds. Instead of parks, asramas. Instead of hotels, temples. Instead of ostentatious excess, simple austerity. Instead of the desire to harness its mighty forces to the chariot of human utility, an absorbing subjectivity, a complete detachment from the body and the outward world to feed the life of the spirit!
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> Thus, the institution of pilgrimage is undeniably a most powerful instrument for developing the geographical sense in the people which enables them to think and feel that India is not a mere congeries of geographical fragments, but a single, though immense, organism, filled with the tide of one strong pulsating life from end to end. The visit to holy places as an imperative religious duty has made wide travelling a national habit in India in all ages of life, with young and old alike, and